Neferti-iti

By Ethyl Eichelberger

INTRODUCTION

Nefertiti was the wife of the Egyptian Pharaoh Amenhotep IV (later Akhenaten), and mother-in-law of the Pharaoh Tutankhamun. Her name roughly translates to "the beautiful one is come". Famed throughout the ancient world for her outstanding beauty, Nefertiti remains the one of the most well known Queen of Egypt. Though Akhenaten had several wives, Queen Nefertiti was his chief wife. Nefertiti joined her husband in worship of a new religion that celebrated the power of the sun-disk Aten - a god of light. In this religion, she was a priest. Supposedly, It was only through the combined royal pair, that the full blessing of god Aten could be bestowed.

May I introduce you to the woman who was . . . . . Neferti-iti by Etyhl Eichelberger.

Ancient Egypt, Eighteenth Dynasty, inside the royal sunshade of Nefert-iti. The Egyptian queen has barricaded herself inside the tomb built for her by her husband Akhenaten. Her sisters and her lover, Bek, the artist who created the queen's famed bust, pay visits, yet remains locked outside the tomb.

Thank Aten I'm a beautiful woman!

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Without that I'd have nothing, no one, nor my self-respect!

(" Impassioned hormones" with a need to be expressed,

a professional woman,

a serious live-er of life!)

Quel joie to be alone each day here in this lovely sunshade Akhenaten built me!

Today is different, though

All Egypt will regret!

(Laughter like the tinkling of bells is heard from offstage.)

It's lovely here

with no one telling me what to do!

No one turning my priceless uniqueness into worthless guilt!

Sometimes in this sunshade I have the distinct feeling I'm being watched, but I am alone here, you can see that!

(Knocking is heard on tomb door.)

There is a knocking at my temple door-who could it be?

I'll ignore the eager knock!

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Go away, there's no one here! *(Listens at door.)*

I won't go back to Memphis-I won't! You can't make me!

Scarcity is valued, so value me--

I've made myself scarce!

I'll keep right on praying to Aten, thank you.

I'm too old to change! Time is running out!

There just aren't enough hours in the day to worship all those other gods again!

Besides, I've sworn my Ka to Aten, the one and only God, the god whose golden rays come streaming down to give me life!

(Knocking is again heard on tomb door.) Go 'way!

No not Osiris;

I won't let my beautiful body be shriveled into a dried-up image of Osiris

Give me life, give me the globe, Aten;

I have no need to be preserved forever,

when I'm dead and gone they'll not forget me!

"She passed like a meteor, leaving the world astonished and amazed!" *(Knocking on door continues.)*

Stop that pounding and send for Bek-

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Have him make a bust of me, then carve my thoughts beneath it.

And for Aten's sake make sure he carves my cartouche right this time; there is only one uraeus, not two!

My dear, if Bek paid as much attention to his work as he did to his diet, something would get done around here!

Tell me, what good are lazy people?

Everybody has to work!

I don't mind ...

I love to work; the busier the better! Fill my life with work!

But my father is a military genius,

I've always been moderately wealthy and relatively unhappy -- could have spoiled me rotten, but he didn't-

He cracked the whip at home and made us girls work!

"People who don't work are bums," he taught us! "Bums!"

What does he know? Who does he think he is anyway?

The father of God!

Casta diva ...

Oh, Aten, make father Ay butt out of my life!

He doesn't give me credit for anything!

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I've had to claw my way to the sanctity of this sunshade!
Isis knows it hasn't been easy!
It's a lot of hard work being a queen!
And there are factions out there who don't like what I represent!
Tough noogies!
I have a right to be here!
Don't do that here!
"Don't be a queen," they say!
The kinder ones tell me that I transcend queenery-
They let me know they'll overlook my queenly failings and benignly be so gracious as to accept me as one of them.
It's true most people would rather queens should stay under wraps, so to speak!
Hide!
Deny your feminine soul!
Being a queen frightens them!
But I am a queen, a beautiful one, at that!
I know who I am!

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Ms. Marcia and I share the same madnessI have seen it in a dream!
If my soul were to present itself to me within a miraculous vision,
I would have that soul emblazoned on my back for all the world to see! *(Knocking on tomb door starts again.)*
Quit pounding on that door!
You're giving me a headache.
I don't care if the Hittites are coming I won't come out!
Oh, go on, I'm not afraid!
They wouldn't dare come in here! I am safe here!
This is a magic place!
Aten will protect me ...
(More knocking on tomb door is heard.) What light, lovely knocking now!
Mut-Nodjme, Honey, is that you, my sweet little sister?
No, Dear-heart, I shan't come out again
I've decided to refuge myself in here forever.
Oooeee, what is that awful stench?
Mut, Honey, have you got those stinking dwarves with you again?

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I don't care if the Mitannia emperor did give them to you, do you have to take them everywhere you go?

I will not shut up! I don't *care* if I hurt their little feelings!

Let them hang around your sunshade!

Mut-Nodjme, don't go away mad!

Mut-Nodjme!

Gone!

Have a pleasant voyage back to Memphis!

I'll miss you, light of my life!

She's such a sweet girl -ambitious-

But she's nice, my little Nodjme!

Whoever followed me about and aped my ways!

Will I never ever see happy Mut-Nodjme?

She'll remember me kindly all her days!

I'm hot!

The Aten's globe has risen to its zenith! Now is the time to pray! *(Starts to play dulcimer and sing-stops.)*

Merytaten should be here to shake her little sistrum while I play-ah, children!!!

What can you do with them?

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All she cares for is that foolish Smenkhare and his vegetarian ways!

She'll be sorry!

Where is Meketaten now?

I miss her so! ... *(pause.)*

Oh, I won't let myself get started on that; not now!

This is a joyous day! I must think positive!

If Ankhesenpaten were here, she'd tell me a joke and tickle her little Neferneferura!

Ah, three lovely children have I now,

even though three lovely more have died -three daughters live while three have passed overthree out of six-not bad,

could have been worse!

Praise be to Aten ... *(plays dulcimer and sings.)*

And here I sit alone-" I'm never bored!"

This must be what life is like to barren people, disciples of Seth with never hope of having children-actually, it's not so bad, I rather like having no one's company but my own! *(Picks up hand mirror and looks into* it.)

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I know who I am-
you know who I am-
and then there is the real me who grins and hides from sight!
Thank goodness I've brought clay tablets and senet games!
I'll summon Thoth and write 'til day is done!
Thoth- Thoth*(No response.)* and here I sit alone!
Dear Aunt Tiye once told me:
"Being alone is not the worst thing in the world!" -But, it is!!! Yes it is-
it's horrible=deplorable->
especially when the Aten begins his nightly journey beneath the Nile!
Where are my lover's arms to hold me!
Oh for pity's sake!
I hereby choose to be alone-
I renounce my children; I have no children,
I renounce my husband; I have no husband
my belief in the Aten will sustain me-

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I have my beliefs in one God to guide me! *(Knocking on tomb door starts again.)*
Cease knocking-
I won't go back to Memphis, I won't; you can't make me!
There just aren't enough hours in the day to worship all those other godsI am a student of the late Amenophis-son-of-Hapu who has given me the strength to fight for my
belief in Tiye, no, not "Inti," but "Aten!" *(Listens at tomb door.)*
Who sighs beside my door and stirs the desert's silence?
Is it you at last?
The sound of your voice awakens flowers in my heart!
Go away!
Do not tempt me!
Let me feel nothing once again!
Yes, I long to see you, hold you, give myself up to my caged desires like I did when you first looked into my eyes-
Do I make no sense?

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I never asked you to understand me
Joy was mine when you but listened!
No, it is too late-our lives got in the way!
No, no! Of course I love you!
You are the divine father, my lover, the sacred
possessor of Min's phallic treasures!
Call me by my rightful name again and sing to me of
happiness, make hunger fly my aching heart!
I do not choose to hear them, Bek!
For me they do not exist!
While you stand close, all I can hear are fleet gazelle
and leopards screaming when the hounds have dragged
them down!
Oh bless you, simplicity becomes you,
it is I who am pretentious-
But you will always remain in my mind
if I may use your own words: "Pretentiously
unpretentious!"
All right, for Aten's sake, labels, labels, labels!
Forgive me, I've offended you again! ...
But we don't change, do we?

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... Good-bye! ...
Yes, I'm telling you to go! Would you rob me of
my few remaining shreds of dignity!
Leave me, let me be! I was happy before I needed you!
No, I'm neither happy nor unhappy!
I try not to think about it anymore! I exist! ...
Of course I have survived!
There was nothing left inside me to destroy after you
had had your way ...
Oh, please don't leave just yet! ...
Yes, I do remember well! It was early morning!
I was gazing out upon the azure Nile when suddenly I
knew
this homely, snoring stranger lying next to me with beer
upon his breath was surely the greatest love of my life
and I would live forever needing him alone!
It made me violently depressed!
Somehow I felt short-changed, tricked, cheated.
Were you what I had lived for, hoped for, longed for all
my days?
Yee-gods! "What next," I thought! ...

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Am I repeating myself again?

Yes, yes, of course I would do anything!

I won't go back to Memphis, I won't; you can't make me!

No, I can't come out, I give myself to God.

I no longer belong to your race!

I have given myself up to the great Aten from whom I spring each morning when the sacred lotus blooms anew!

Sometimes I truly wish with all my might that I were a human being instead of whatever it is I am!

I can feel, I want to be like the rest!

I have a right to some sort of life like other people.

Bek, Dear-heart, it's just not that easy!

Let myself fall in love again? With whom if not with you?

Oh, a lovely thought-

the maiden returning from the tryst with a functioning looney on her arm!

And what could I offer him, sagging flesh and swollen eyes?

Bek, Bek, you're most kind!

Yes, they'll say I was a lost woman; only my bust was found!

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That splendid bust!

Do you really still have it where it was?

Bek, what must your wife think?

If only life could imitate art!

If only it were true that truth is beauty!

I can speak true!

But if truth were beauty, more girls would get their hair done at the library!

Yes, no, of course I've brought my mirror, what queen would be without one?

All right, I'll look into it once again! Yes! Is that what you have seen?

No! Must I say?

Bek, what I see couldn't turn a trick in Boy's Town!

No, I'm not being negative!

Go then, back to your wife and leave me be!

What do you need me for?

You can create alone! You are an artist!

Bek, I didn't mean it! Bek There is no key to let you in!

Please don't accuse me of being negative again!

I couldn't stand it! I am trying! I am trying!

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I will be positive!

Oh, God, don't leave me again, Bek. I couldn't stand it to be alone, abandoned!

Bek, talk to me! Say something!

Bek, Almighty Aten, bring him back! Bek!

Don't leave me here to die alone!

All right, I'm through.

You have won.

I don't believe in you-

Is that what you want me to say?

I curse you, I curse the name of the Aten.

I believe in nothing.

Strike me dead if you will! I don't believe in you!

There is no chance of everlasting life!

When I am dead, my detractors will erase my face and name from every building, every tablet, every wall!

Bek will leave my image here to crumble into dust when he goes back to Memphis!

The name of Nefert-iti will be gone forever! No one will remember who I am!

I know what will be said:

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"Who is Achenchae, Nefertiti who?" "I've never heard of Akhenastae!

Who was she?"

Aten has tricked me! I believed in a calf of gold!

Hear me, Aten, I believe in you no more!

You are hateful!

You lied when in a blast of fire you told me you were coming back to get me!

You have abandoned me! I hate you! I hate you!

Oh, why have you forsaken me?

What have I said? What does it matter?

Talk is cheap in the end Where is the Kohl to stain my eyes?

Where is camel hair ground to bruise my lips?

There is no one left to help me! I must carry on alone?!

I have driven all away!

Once I had many friends and lovers, they are all gone now; life goes on

(Drinks poison. Plays dulcimer and sings "The Song of Abandon.") Give me a sign, kind Aten!

Send gentle spirits down to join my dance!

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Is there no justice in the world? Must I accept what comes my way?

No! I am fighting back!

There must be some sort of justice, even in Egypt!

I demand it!

I won't be thrown out the door like yesterday's dinner to be eaten by crocodiles or hippopotami!

I must be worth more than that, I can still learn!

Hapu's son taught me to be forever a student!

To be learned is to be trained for a world already gone, he said.

Change, change and more change!

It's happening fast-too fast!

Busy, busy, busy, but I'm never too busy to count my assets!

That's rule #1 in business and I have assets, Aten, hear me! I can work hard and long!

I can listen!

For a while, at least, I can be trusted!

I am a true friend to a few and kind to many

I can love,

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I've been burned once too often! You are looking at damaged goods!

I have been abandoned! I can't find my way! Aten, do something! Help me! I beseech you!

I will not be ignored any longer!

Look at me!

Acknowledge me!

React or something

Give me a sign!

Aten! Aten! Aten!

I've had it! Hapu's son was wrong! Believe in the one true God, he said and you will have everlasting life!

(Nefert-iti dies.)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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